

EVERY TEACHER

Because every teacher is a language teacher.

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Six weeks of silence is not six weeks of nothing

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FROM THE EDITOR

You have them longer than I do.

Your EL specialist sees that student for one block. You see them for five. Whatever language they build this year, most of it will be built in your room, in the middle of content you were already going to teach.

That is not a complaint about your workload. It is the actual math of language acquisition, and it is the reason this magazine exists. Nothing in this issue requires a certification, a budget, or a free period. Every technique here can be run on Monday with the lesson already sitting in your plan book.

What it does require is a shift: from asking *how do I make this easier for them* to asking *how do I make this reachable*. Those are not the same question, and only one of them ends with a student who can do grade-level work.



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Editor · EL Publishing

NEWCOMERS

The quiet one

A student who has said nothing for six weeks is not a student who has learned nothing. Knowing the difference is the single most useful thing a content teacher can carry into September.

Comprehension runs ahead of production in every language, for every learner, at every age. Infants understand hundreds of words before they say one. Adult learners of Spanish follow a conversation months before they can join it. Your newcomer is in the same place, and the technical name for it is the silent period.

It can last a few weeks or the better part of a year. It is more visible in younger students, but it happens at every age, and in high school it is frequently mistaken for something else: shyness, apathy, defiance, or a learning disability. That misreading is the most consequential error a general-education teacher makes with newcomers, and it is the one this page exists to prevent.

What is actually happening. The student is doing enormous work. They are mapping sound to meaning, sorting which noises are words, finding the boundaries between them, and testing hypotheses about grammar they will not be able to explain for years. None of that is visible from your desk. Silence

Never cold-call into silence. Calling on a newcomer without warning, in front of thirty peers, in a language they cannot yet produce, teaches one lesson reliably: that your class is dangerous. Rehearse first. Let them say it to a partner, then to you, then to the room — in that order, over weeks, not minutes.

Do not fill the silence for them. The reflex to answer your own question after two seconds removes the only processing time the student has. Ask, then wait, and count to five in your head. It will feel unbearable. It is not.

Do not lower the content. Silence is a language stage, not a cognitive ceiling. The student who cannot yet explain the causes of the Civil War in English may understand them completely in Spanish. Give them the map, the timeline, and the same question everyone else got.

And do not refer yet. A special education referral made before a student has had adequate time and adequate instruction in English cannot distinguish a language difference from a disability. It is educationally unsound and, at the district level,

WHEN SILENCE IS TELLING YOU SOMETHING ELSE

The silent period is normal. These four patterns are not, and each one is worth a conversation with your EL specialist rather than a wait-and-see.

No response in the first language either. If a same-language peer or a family member reports the student is equally unresponsive in Spanish, the issue is not English.

Comprehension is flat across a semester. Production can stall for months. Understanding should not. If nonverbal checks show no growth from August to December, that is data.

Interrupted or limited prior schooling. A student who has missed years of school is not on the same trajectory as a student who was at grade level in their home country. The instructional plan has to be different.

A student who was talking and stopped. Regression is not part of the silent period. Something changed — check in, and loop in a counselor.

ARRIVALS

The first ten days

A newcomer joined your fourth period this morning. No file, no warning, no shared language. Here is what matters, in the order it matters.

DAY ONE — BEFORE THE BELL RINGS AGAIN

- 1 **Learn the name.** Ask the student to say it. Say it back. Ask again. Write it phonetically in your own notes and practice it before tomorrow. Mispronouncing a student's name for a month communicates something you do not intend to communicate, and it is the cheapest thing on this list to get right.
- 2 **Seat them in the middle.** Not the back, not the door, not beside your desk. Central seating puts them inside the flow of peer talk, which is where most incidental language actually comes from.
- 3 **Assign a buddy, not an interpreter.** A warm, reliable peer who shows them where things are. If a same-language peer is available, excellent — but do not make that student your full-time translator. That is two students not learning. Rotate the role after two weeks.
- 4 **Give five phrases, not a curriculum.** On an index card: *I don't understand. Please repeat. Can you help me? Where is the bathroom? How do you say ___?* Survival language buys dignity in week one.
- 5 **Do not assess today.** Whatever you give them will measure English, not knowledge, and it will sit in your gradebook all semester looking like a fact.

DAYS TWO THROUGH SEVEN

- 6 **Label the room.** Objects, procedures, the daily agenda. A labeled room is comprehensible input running all period without you doing anything.
- 7 **Hand them paper.** Everything you put on the board, they get on a page. Copying from a distance in a new alphabet consumes the attention they need for content.
- 8 **Allow the translation tool, with a rule.** A translator is an access device, not a shortcut. Set the boundary — for meaning, not for producing whole assignments — and then stop policing it.
- 9 **Allow the first language.** Let them think, draft, annotate, and talk with a peer in Spanish. Suppressing the first language does not accelerate English; it removes the scaffold English is being built on.
- 10 **Ask for one word.** By day four, output starts. One word. Then a phrase. Then a frame. The size of the ask grows; the expectation of some response does not waver.

DAYS EIGHT THROUGH TEN — BUILD THE THING THAT REPEATS

- 11 **Make the routine visible and identical.** Same opening, same signal, same closing, same place on the board. Predictability is comprehensible input: when the structure is known, all of the student's processing goes to the content instead of to figuring out what is happening.
- 12 **Call home first, and call with good news.** In the family's language, through the district's interpretation service if you have one. The first contact sets the terms of every contact after it.
- 13 **Find the EL specialist and ask three questions.** What is this student's ELPA21 level in each domain? What accommodations are documented in the LSP? What did their prior schooling look like? Those three answers change almost everything you do next.

The buddy who translates all day is a kindness to one student and a cost to two. Rotate the role, and keep both of them in the lesson.

WHAT NOT TO DO IN WEEK ONE

Don't pull them from electives. Art, PE, band, and shop are frequently the only classes where a newcomer can perform at grade level and belong to something. Pulling them for intervention takes the win away.

Don't park a paraprofessional beside them permanently. An adult in the next chair ends peer interaction, which is where most language actually gets built.

Don't hand them a worksheet while the class discusses. Separate work signals separate membership. Give them a role in the discussion instead — a card to hold up, a diagram to point at, a frame to read aloud.

Don't wait for the file. Records may take weeks. Everything on these two pages works without them.

THE THREE QUESTIONS, AND WHY

ELPA21 level, by domain. A student can be Level 4 in listening and Level 1 in writing. One number hides that. The domain profile tells you which channel to use tomorrow.

What's in the LSP. Documented accommodations are not suggestions, and using them only on test day does not satisfy anyone — they have to live in daily instruction.

Prior schooling. A student who finished ninth grade in Honduras and a student who last attended school in fourth grade are both newcomers and need almost nothing in common from you.

INSTRUCTION

Amplify, don't simplify.

The instinct to make the work easier is usually the instinct to make it useless. There is a better move, and it is not more work.

Simplification takes things out. The vocabulary comes down, the sentences get shorter, the task gets smaller, and what is left is a version of the lesson that teaches less. Do it for a year and the gap you were trying to close has widened, because the student has been practicing easier material than their peers the entire time.

Amplification adds things in. Same content, same grade-level expectation, more ways in: an image, a demonstration, a graphic organizer, a partner rehearsal, a sentence frame, a glossary handed out before the reading instead of after it. The work stays hard. The road to it gets wider.

The distinction comes out of Aída Walqui's scaffolding research, and it is the most useful single idea in this magazine. Every move below is a form of amplification.

It is also the cheaper of the two options over a semester. Simplifying means building a second, parallel version of every task. Amplifying means building the supports once — the frames, the visuals, the glossary — and reusing them across every unit for every student who needs a way in, including the

- 1 **Frontload. Don't backfill.** Give the eight words and the text the day before, not the review sheet the day after. A student who arrives already holding the vocabulary can spend the period on the thinking.
- 2 **Chunk at eight minutes.** No more than eight to ten minutes of teacher talk without a thirty-second partner turn. The turn is not a break from the lesson; it is where the language gets used.
- 3 **Make your talk visible.** Write the key term as you say it. Point to it when it comes back. Spoken words disappear at the speed of speech; written ones wait.
- 4 **Wait five seconds.** Average teacher wait time after a question is around one second. A student translating, processing, formulating, and then translating back needs five or more. The silence is the instruction.
- 5 **Rehearse before you call.** "Turn and tell your partner" and then call on someone. Now every student in the room has already said it once, which converts cold-calling from a threat into a repetition.
- 6 **Give the frame, not the answer.** *I think ___ because ___.*

THE TEST

Hold your adaptation up against one question: would a native speaker doing this version be learning the same thing?

If yes, you amplified. If no, you simplified, and the student is now on a different curriculum than the one they will be tested on.

A shorter text on the same topic, at the same grade level, is amplification. A third-grade text on the same topic is not.

A word bank on the essay is amplification. Replacing the essay with matching is not.

Fewer problems at the same difficulty is amplification. The same number of easier problems is not.

What it looks like in your room

Mathematics

The barrier is almost never the arithmetic — it is the word problem. Teach comparison language explicitly (*more than, less than, twice as many, per, each, remaining*) because it is the language, not the operation, that decides whether a student can start. Let students show the work before they write the explanation, and give full content credit for a correct solution inside an imperfect sentence. Keep the numbers grade level; change the sentence around them.

Science

Your subject has an advantage nobody else has: the phenomenon is comprehensible without English. A reaction in a beaker means the same thing in every language. Run the lab first and name it afterward, label the diagram before the lecture rather than after, and lean hard on the cognate load — *energía, molécula, célula, experimento, observación* — which is heavier in science than in any other content area.

Social studies

The problem is density: long paragraphs, embedded clauses, idiom, and an enormous amount of assumed background. Never assume shared knowledge of American civics, geography, or holidays. Build the lesson on a timeline, a map, or an image and let the text support the visual instead of the other way around. Ask what the same event looked like from where the student is from — it is good history and it turns their background into an asset.

English language arts

The trap is grading the language when you meant to grade the thinking. A student can have a sophisticated reading of a text and no way yet to write it. Let them read a shorter or first-language version of the same work and join the same discussion, respond orally or in bullets, and be assessed on the interpretation. Save the sentence-level correction for a draft where language is the objective.

A simplified text teaches a student less than their classmates learned. That is not support. Amplification keeps the content and widens the road in.

TWO MINUTES OF PLANNING THAT PAY FOR THEMSELVES

Pick the eight words. Not twenty-five. Eight words that unlock this unit, taught before it starts, with an image beside each one.

Write one frame on the board. The frame you want to hear in the discussion. Leave it up all period.

Decide your nonverbal check. Thumbs, red/green cards, a four-corner sort. Decide before the lesson which one you will use, or you will default to "any questions?" — a check that returns no information from anyone.

ASSESSMENT

Grading what you meant to grade

If the objective was photosynthesis, spelling is not the grade. Most EL grading problems are this one problem.

Read the response for the idea first. Find the content — the claim, the process, the answer, the reasoning — and mark that. Then make a deliberate decision about whether language is part of this particular objective. Most of the time it is not, and the marks you were about to make in the margin belong on a different assignment.

A failing grade caused by English is not a measure of learning. It is a measure of access, recorded in a place where it will be read as ability for the rest of the student's schooling.

Accommodation or modification. An accommodation changes how a student shows what they know: extra time, a glossary, an oral response, a word bank. A modification changes *what* they are expected to know. Modifying grade-level content should be rare and documented — a modified curriculum, repeated across four years, is a diploma that does not mean what the transcript says.

Test the content, not the stem. Rewriting question stems is the highest-yield twenty minutes you will spend on assessment. A stem built out of academic phrasing is a reading item wearing a science costume.

REWRITE THE STEM

Which of the following best exemplifies...

Which one is an example of...

Analyze the extent to which...

How much did ___ change? Give two reasons.

What can be inferred from the passage?

What does the writer want you to understand?

Describe the significance of...

Why was ___ important?

FOUR ACCOMMODATIONS THAT COST NOTHING

Accept an oral answer. Thirty seconds at your desk while the class works. You learn more about what the student knows than the written version would ever tell you.

Accept bullet points. If the objective is the reasoning, the paragraph is packaging.

Put the word bank on the test. Recall of English spelling is rarely the standard you are assessing.

Allow a first-language response for verifiable content. A translation tool or your EL specialist can confirm it. A right answer in Spanish is a right answer.

None of these lower the standard. All of them separate what the student knows from how fast they can currently produce English.

TOOLKIT

Ten minutes, ten moves

A prep-period checklist. Nothing here needs materials you do not have.

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>☐ 01 Post the objective in student words
"You will explain why ice floats" beats the standard code. Read it aloud at the start and again at the end.</p> | <p>☐ 06 Count to five before you take an answer
Out loud in your head. Then take the answer. This one change alters who participates in your class.</p> |
| <p>☐ 02 Preteach five words, not twenty-five
Choose the words that unlock the lesson, not every unfamiliar word. Put an image next to each.</p> | <p>☐ 07 Rehearse in pairs before you call on anyone
Cold-calling after a partner turn is safe. Cold-calling into silence is not.</p> |
| <p>☐ 03 Put one visual on every slide
A photograph, a diagram, an icon. If a slide is only text, an EL gets nothing from it in real time.</p> | <p>☐ 08 Hand over the notes
Copying from the board is a transcription task, not a learning task. Give the page and spend the time on meaning.</p> |
| <p>☐ 04 Write the frame on the board
The sentence you want to hear back. Leave it up. Point at it when you ask the question.</p> | <p>☐ 09 Let the dictionary stay open
Bilingual dictionary, glossary, translation tool. Set the rule once and stop enforcing it every period.</p> |
| <p>☐ 05 Chunk your talk at eight minutes
Then thirty seconds of partner talk with a specific prompt. Not "discuss" — a question with an answer.</p> | <p>☐ 10 Check comprehension without words
Thumbs, red/green cards, a card sort, point-to-the-diagram. "Any questions?" tells you nothing.</p> |

LANGUAGE

The free vocabulary

Roughly a third of academic English has a Spanish twin. Most of your students do not know that until an adult points at it.

Everyday English is largely Germanic. Academic English is largely Latinate. That single fact produces the most counterintuitive advantage your Spanish speakers have: the hard-sounding word is often the easy one. *Observe* is closer to Spanish than *look at*. *Construct* is closer than *build*. *Sufficient* is closer than *enough*. Which means the plain-English paraphrase you offered to help may have made the sentence harder.

Teach the endings, not the words. Eight suffix patterns unlock thousands of items at once, and unlike a word list they keep working after your unit ends.

SEVEN PATTERNS

-tion → -ción	nation, education, information
-ty → -dad	community, university, activity
-ous → -oso	famous, curious, generous
-ment → -mento	moment, document, experiment
-ly → -mente	rapidly, exactly, finally
-ic → -ico	electric, specific, historic
-ance → -ancia	importance, distance, tolerance

THE THIRTY-SECOND ROUTINE

Once per lesson, on one word, ask the room: does this look like a Spanish word you know?

That is the whole intervention. It costs half a minute, it hands the analysis to the students instead of to you, and it teaches a strategy they can run on their own for the rest of their lives. Monolingual English speakers get something out of it too — they are learning morphology.

AND THE ONES THAT LIE

éxito	success — not <i>exit</i>
librería	bookstore — not <i>library</i>
asistir	to attend — not <i>assist</i>
actualmente	currently — not <i>actually</i>
realizar	to carry out — not <i>realize</i>
sensible	sensitive — not <i>sensible</i>
carpeta	folder — not <i>carpet</i>
ropa	clothes — not <i>rope</i>

ONE CONDITION

Cognate strategy depends on literacy in Spanish. A student who reads Spanish well can transfer thousands of words across in a semester. A student with interrupted schooling, who does not yet read fluently in any language, has nothing to transfer *from* — and for that student cognate instruction is a decoding lesson in two languages at once, not a shortcut.

Ask your EL specialist which of your students is which. The answer changes the strategy completely, and it is not visible from the seating chart.

COMPLIANCE

What the law actually requires

Language support is not a courtesy your school extends to families. It is an obligation the school already owes them.

THE FIVE THAT MATTER

Lau v. Nichols (1974)	Giving English learners the same books, teachers, and curriculum as everyone else is not equal treatment when they cannot understand the language of instruction. Identical is not equal.
Title VI, Civil Rights Act of 1964	Bars national-origin discrimination in any program receiving federal funds. Failure to provide meaningful access to the curriculum is national-origin discrimination — which is why EL services are a civil-rights matter, not a program option.
Equal Educational Opportunities Act (1974)	Requires "appropriate action to overcome language barriers." It names no method — which is what made the next case necessary.
Castañeda v. Pickard (1981)	The three-part test: sound educational theory; effective implementation with trained staff; and real results — if the barrier is not coming down, the program has to change.
Plyler v. Doe (1982)	Schools may not deny enrollment over a child's immigration status, or demand documents that would discourage a family from enrolling.

A language service plan is not a list of suggestions. It is how the district meets a federal obligation — in your room.

WHAT THIS MEANS AT YOUR DESK

Documented accommodations are not optional. Declining one is not a grading philosophy; it is the district falling short in your room.

They belong in instruction, not only on test day. An accommodation a student has never used before the state test is a surprise, not a support.

Enrollment questions are not yours to ask. Route anything touching a family's status to administration.

IN MISSISSIPPI

State-assessment accommodations follow the Mississippi Testing Accommodations Manual, and the rule is the one at left: it must already be routine in instruction.

English learner progress on ELPA21 carries weight in school accountability — the growth happening in your content class is measured whether or not anyone told you.

General information, not legal advice. For specifics, your district's federal programs office is the right call.

One thing to try Monday.

If you read nothing else in this issue, run this one.

1 Ask the question.

The real one, at grade level. Do not soften it.

2 Say: turn and tell your partner.

Thirty seconds. Everyone talks, including the student who never volunteers.

3 Count to five.

Silently, after you call the room back. Do not fill it.

4 Then call on someone.

Anyone. It is now safe, because every student in the room has already said an answer out loud once.

It takes ninety seconds. It changes who is in your lesson.



NEXT ISSUE

Students with interrupted formal education · Co-teaching that isn't just two adults in one room · Reclassification, and what happens after exit

EL PUBLISHING

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